and Bomdila—by the evening of 18 November. Ever since the first shots were fired in October, the majority of Indian commanders had time and again demonstrated to the Chinese that the moment they felt their rear threatened, they lost their nerve and the will to fight. The Chinese in turn had taken a huge risk by pushing forward, dangerously stretching their lines of communication. Under normal circumstances, a competent higher headquarters (IV Corps in this case) would have welcomed the Chinese thrust, isolated their already extended troops and then mopped them up. Instead, despite the fact the chief (Pran Thapar), the army commander (Bogey Sen) and the corps commander (Bijji Kaul) were present in the Ops Room in Tezpur, they watched helplessly as all three so-called defensive hubs—Se-la, Dirang Dzong and Bomdila—disintegrated before their eyes.

It was not the Chinese that defeated the Indian Army but the so-called ‘senior leadership’ of the army; almost all the brigade commanders failed miserably in NEFA, as did the GOCs of 4 Infantry Division. The three ranking officers, who collectively proved to be completely at sea and failed to instil in their subordinates the confidence to stand their ground, further compounded their failure. The shame of the defeat was followed by a surge of public anger, and Nehru, Krishna Menon and Bijji Kaul became the focal points at whose feet India’s defeat was laid. In a way, this acted as a smokescreen and most of the culprits responsible for the debacle got away scot-free. None of the senior officers were censored or brought to book.

The collapse is best illustrated by the events that unfolded in the Ops Room of IV Corps on 18 November. While the early morning had been dominated by the stunning collapse of 62 Brigade at Se-la, midday had seen HQ 4 Infantry Division with the Dirang Dzong garrison implode as well. News from Bomdila had not yet come in, but even there the battle was over before it started.

By noon, everyone in the Ops Room knew that there was going to be no miracle that would suddenly reverse the situation in NEFA. Palit later wrote: ‘There was a nightmarish quality about the proceedings in the Corps Ops Room. The three senior commanders held a number of discussions in which opinions gyrated freely but were seldom to the point. In the midst of the most acute military crisis the nation had faced in centuries, none seemed able to stretch his strategic horizon to take in the full significance of the situation. Instead, they kept moving round and round in circles of futile argument.’